

Characters and their Mentions

Annotation Guidelines (ver. 5.0)

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1) Introduction

The aim of annotation is to identify which characters appear in a novel and where they appear. The following guidelines specify how to proceed and what is meant by the categories provided.

Conceptually, the guidelines are permeated by a distinction between the “prototypical case” on the one hand and “special and borderline cases” on the other. We explicitly do not want to say anything about the frequency of the phenomena described with these terms. In other words, we do not wish to suggest that the prototypical case is particularly common and special and borderline cases particularly rare. On the contrary, depending on the text, ‘special cases’ may also occur particularly frequently. Instead, the terms refer to how prototypical we consider the cases to be in relation to the subject we are interested in, i.e., characters and their mentions.

First, in section 2), we explain the practical procedure for annotation using the program INCEpTION. We only touch on the key terms very superficially, as the main aim here is to clarify the annotation workflow. Section 3) explains the categories for prototypical cases and sets out rules for handling them. When annotating, we always start from this prototypical case as the phenomenon we are ultimately concerned with. Section 4) deals with special and borderline cases: It defines the applicable rules and explains the cases that form separate categories in the annotation. Section 5) defines the level of knowledge that should be considered decisive for annotation as a whole. Our approach follows a *static* perspective: knowledge is modeled on the basis of the complete text, rather than being updated incrementally as information becomes available in the course of reading. As with all other aspects of these guidelines, this choice reflects a modeling decision rather than a requirement imposed by the phenomena under investigation. Section 6 provides a concise guide to setting up an annotation project in the INCEpTION annotation tool in order to annotate texts according to the present guidelines. For ease of navigation, the names of layers, tags, and features are listed in parentheses after the chapter headings in which they are primarily discussed.

Our guidelines are primarily based on those proposed by Krug et al. 2016, but extend them with more fine-grained rules, particularly with respect to special and borderline cases. In doing so, we incorporate clarifications of special cases discussed in other guidelines and publications on the coreference annotation of literary texts (notably Roesiger et al. 2018; Bamman et al. 2020), as well as cases that emerged in the course of our own annotation practice.

The examples used throughout these guidelines are generally drawn from texts that we have manually annotated, either partially or in full. In parentheses, we indicate the abbreviated titles used throughout the remainder of the guidelines:

- Friedrich Maximilian Klinger (1795): *Der Faust der Morgenländer* (*Faust of the Orient*, Klinger, *Faust*)
- Caroline Auguste Fischer (1801): *Gustavs Verirrungen* (*Gustav’s Misadventures*, Fischer, *Gustav*)

- Johann Wolfgang Goethe (1809): *Die Wahlverwandtschaften* (*Elective Affinities*, Goethe, *Wahlverwandtschaften*)
- Ferdinand Kürnberger (1855): *Der Amerika-Müde* (*The Weary of America*, Kürnberger, *Amerika-Müder*)
- Julius Wolff (1877): *Das Wildfangrecht* (*The Right of the Wildfang*, Wolff, *Wildfangrecht*)
- Wilhelmine Heimbürg (1894): *Trudchens Heirat* (*Trudchen's Marriage*, Heimbürg, *Trudchen*)

The guidelines are formulated as if the texts were annotated without any prior preprocessing. In practice, however, the texts are not presented in raw form, but in a preprocessed, semi-automated version.

The guidelines were originally formulated in German. They were translated to English based on suggestions from DeepL and GPT.

2) Annotation Procedure

2.1 Basic Task

We draw a fundamental distinction between a character as an entity of the narrated world (e.g., Eduard in *Elective Affinities*) and its mentions in the text (e.g., the expressions “Eduard” and “Baron” at the beginning of the novel). When we speak of a *character* or *entity*, we refer to the former level. When we speak of a (*character*) *mention* or simply a *mention*, we refer to the latter level. If two mentions refer to the same character, they are considered *coreferent*.

The basic task consists in identifying and tagging all character mentions in the text and assigning them, via an ID, to the character to which they refer.

Annotation is carried out on a chapter-by-chapter basis: each chapter is annotated as a separate file in the annotation tool INCEpTION.

In the following screenshot from INCEpTION, the words *Eduard*, *Baron*, and *seiner* are shown as mentions of the character Eduard. These mentions are marked using the *Mention* layer, and an identifier is assigned in the *ID* field that uniquely and consistently labels the character within the chapter.

1	Erstes Kapitel
2	Eduard – so nennen wir einen reichen Baron im besten Mannesalter – Eduard hatte in seiner Baumschule die schönste Stunde
3	eines Aprilmittags zugebracht, um frisch erhaltene Pflanzfreier auf junge Stämme zu bringen. Sein Geschäft war eben
4	vollendet; er legte die Gerätschaften in das Futteral zusammen und betrachtete seine Arbeit mit Vergnügen, als der
5	Gärtner einzutrat und sich an dem teilnehmenden Fleiße des Herrn ergetzte.

After completing the annotation of a chapter, we export the file from INCEPTION in XMI format. Using a Python script, we then automatically generate a tabular chapter-level character index from the chapter annotation file.

The individual chapter-level character indices are subsequently merged into a tabular character index for the entire text. In this table, each character in the novel is represented by exactly one entry, i.e., one row. The columns record which IDs were used for that character in the individual chapters. The following figure shows an excerpt from the character index for *Elective Affinities*.

fullname	ID_chapter_1	ID_chapter_2	ID_chapter_3	ID_chapter_4	ID_chapter_5	ID_chapter_6	ID_chapter_7	ID_chapter_8	ID_...
Eduard		Eduard	Eduard	Eduard	Eduard	Eduard	Eduard	Eduard	Eduard
Charlotte		Charlotte	Charlotte	Charlotte	Charlotte	Charlotte	Charlotte	Charlotte	Charlotte
Hauptmann		Hauptmann	Hauptmann	Hauptmann	Hauptmann	Hauptmann	Hauptmann	Hauptmann	Hauptmann
Gärtner		Gärtner							
Luciane		Luciane	Luciane	Luciane		Luciane			
Ottile		Ottile		Ottile		Ottile	Ottile	Ottile	Ottile
Geschwisterpaare die Charlotte kennt		Geschwister							
Liebende die Charlotte kennt		Liebende							
Freunde die Charlotte kennt		Freunde die Charlotte gesehen hat							
Ehepaare die Charlotte kennt		Ehepaare							
Arbeiter in Charlottes Anlage		Arbeiter							
Eduards erste Frau		Eduards erste Frau	Eduards erste Frau						
Eduards Vater		Eduards Vater		Eduards Vater					
Eduards Mutter		Eduards Mutter	Eduards Mutter						
Charlottes erster Mann		Charlottes erster Mann							
Erzählinstanz		Erzähler		Erzähler			Erzähler	Erzähler	
manche tätige Freundinnen von Charlotte		Freundinnen							
manche tätige Freunde von Charlotte		Freunde							
Postbote		Postbote							
gegenwärtige Pächter		Pächter							
Mittler			Mittler						
Ottiles Mutter		Ottiles Mutter							
Vorsteherin der Pension		Vorsteherin der Pension	Vorsteherin			Vorsteherin	Vorsteherin		
Bedienstete		Bedienstete							
Bedienter		Bedienter							
Wer ein Übel los sein will		Wer ein Übel los sein will							
Eduards Eltern		Eduards Eltern							
Ehepaare in Mittlers ehemaliger Gemeinde		Ehepaar							
Bote		Bote							
Charlottes Tante		Charlottes Tante							
Begrabene auf Kirchhof		Begrabene auf Kirchhof							
Bewohner in Mittlers ehemaliger Gemeinde		Bewohner							
Gutbesitzer in Mittlers ehemaliger Gemeinde		Gutbesitzer							
geschickteste Advokaten		geschickteste Advokaten							
vornehme und reiche Leute		vornehme und reiche Leute							
Gehülfe				Gehülfe		Gehülfe	Gehülfe		

2.2 Additional Information about Characters

In addition to this basic information on which character appears where, we record a range of further attributes. In principle, these may pertain either to the character as an entity or to individual mentions.

Entity-level attributes always include the full name (*fullname*) and gender (*gender*). The remaining attributes address special cases and borderline phenomena. All attributes associated with the entity are ultimately recorded in the corresponding columns of the character index. The following figure again shows an excerpt from the character index for *Elective Affinities*, this time including the columns that contain the additional attributes.

A	C	D	E	F	G	H	I	J	K	L
ID_general	fullname	gender	possible_identity_with	members	members_names	specialcase	borderline	comment_entity	ID_chapter_1	ID_chapter_2
entity_0001	Eduard	m								Eduard
entity_0002	Charlotte	f								Charlotte
entity_0003	Hauptmann	m	entity_0374							Hauptmann
entity_0004	Gärtner	m								Gärtner
entity_0005	Luciane	f								Luciane
entity_0006	Ottile	f								Ottile
entity_0007	Geschwisterpaare die Charlotte kennt	u		x	x	group				Geschwister
entity_0008	Liebende die Charlotte kennt	u		x	x	group				Liebende
entity_0009	Freunde die Charlotte kennt	u		x	x	group				Freunde die Charlotte gesehe
entity_0010	Ehepaare die Charlotte kennt	u		x	x	group				Ehepaare
entity_0011	Arbeiter in Charlottes Anlage	u		x	x	group				Arbeiter
entity_0012	Eduards erste Frau	f								Eduards erste Frau
entity_0013	Eduards Vater	m								Eduards Vater
entity_0014	Eduards Mutter	f								Eduards Mutter
entity_0015	Charlottes erster Mann	m								Charlottes erster Mann
entity_0016	Erzählinstanz	u								Erzähler
entity_0017	manche tätige Freundinnen von Charlotte	f		x	x	group				Freundinnen
entity_0018	manche tätige Freunde von Charlotte	m		x	x	group				Freunde

To this end, additional information can either be entered later directly into the corresponding column of the character index, or recorded at the first mention of the character in the text by filling in the appropriate fields in INCEpTION. During transformation with the Python script, this information is transferred to the chapter-level character index and can then be copied into the overall character index.

The choice of workflow does not affect the final result; in practice, however, it is often advisable to record the information directly in INCEpTION, as this makes it easier to recall at a later stage. This is particularly true for special cases and borderline phenomena.

By contrast, additional information that pertains to individual mentions must be recorded together with the mention in INCEpTION. This is straightforward when one considers that such information does not necessarily apply to the character as a whole and therefore does not form part of the entry in the character index.

3) Prototypical Case

3.1 Character Mention

EXPLIKATION

A (character) mention is an explicit reference to a character. By *character*, we mean a human or human-like being in the world constructed by a fictional narrative text. An entity is considered *human-like* if it has an externally perceptible outer side as well as an inner side that is not directly

perceptible from the outside and to which mental states such as intentions, desires, or beliefs can be attributed. All humans in the fictional world are automatically considered characters.

COMMON CASES

Mentions of characters typically occur in three forms:

- **Proper names.** Proper names include, for example, first names, surnames, or family names.
EXAMPLE: *“Well, there are still a few weeks until the reading,” [Madlen] said reassuringly.* (Wolff, Wildfangrecht)¹
- **Common nouns.** Common nouns refer to a being using a name for their type. These can include, for example, occupational terms (e.g., *baker*), relational expressions (e.g., *mother*), gendered terms (e.g., *woman*), titles (e.g., *count*), or substantivized adjectives (e.g., *beauty*).
EXAMPLE: *On a warm September evening, a tall, sturdy [man] with long gray hair sat in front of the house of his homestead in the gracefully situated town of Wachenheim in the Rhineland-Palatinate, gazing pensively ahead.* (Wolff, Wildfangrecht)

Pronouns. Pronouns include, among others, personal pronouns (e.g., *he, she*), possessive pronouns (e.g., *his, her*), reflexive pronouns (e.g., *himself, herself*), and relative pronouns (e.g., *who*).

EXAMPLE: *[He] was dressed in traditional local peasant attire, but [his] bearing and overall appearance had something dignified and commanding of respect.* (Wolff, Wildfangrecht)

ANNOTATION SPAN

For **proper names**, the full name is always annotated.

EXAMPLE: *After a brief table prayer, which the eldest grandson recited fluently but without much devotion, they began to eat, and [Elsbeth] distributed a portion to her two boys, while [Ammerie] filled the cups from the jug.*

“You were still with [Lutz Hebenstreit]?” asked [Christoph]. (Wolff, Wildfangrecht)

Titles and similar elements are treated as part of the name.

EXAMPLE: *“All that remains is for [Junker Ulrich] to appear here as well and pay you his—reverence, Trudi.”* (Wolff, Wildfangrecht)

EXAMPLE: *“[Mr. Mayor], forgive me if I disturb you,” began the old man.* (Wolff, Wildfangrecht)

In all other cases, annotation is performed at the word level; for multi-word noun phrases, only the head of the phrase is annotated.

¹ All quotes from the novels used throughout the guidelines are translated from German to English using DeepL or GPT.

EXAMPLE: The *[descendant]* of an old, proud knightly family and the *[scion]* of an old, free peasant family had soon been frolicking as *[boys]* on the walls and in the ditches of the castle, as well as in the garden and service rooms of the vineyard estate, [...]. (Wolff, Wildfangrecht)

NOTE: Here, for instance, instead of annotating the entire noun phrase “descendant of an old, proud knightly family,” only its head “descendant” is annotated.

If multiple characters are mentioned within a noun phrase (nested structure), each is tagged at its respective head.

EXAMPLE: Two chubby boys, aged ten and eight, *[Christoph’s] [grandsons]*, came rushing around the house, and the first words of the elder were: “Is there still nothing to eat?” (Wolff, Wildfangrecht)

For mentions in appositions, we annotate only the head of the noun phrase and the head of the appositive, not the entire phrase.²

EXAMPLE: *[Ronald]*, the famous *[chamber singer]*, performs in Berlin. (Example from Eisenberg 2020, p. 279)

3.2 Chapter-Wise Unique Identifier (ID) and Coreference

EXPLANATION

Coreference is a relationship between two (or more) mentions that indicates they refer to the same character. When two mentions refer to the same character in this sense, we call them *coreferent*.

In the following example, for instance, the proper name *Peter* and the personal pronoun *he*, as well as the personal pronoun *I* and the name *Elsbeth*, are coreferent:

EXAMPLE: “*[I]* don’t know where *[Peter]* is,” replied *[Elsbeth]*. “*[He]* just wanted to visit Master Cooper Lutz Hebenstreit one more time.” (Wolff, Wildfangrecht)

ANNOTATION PROCEDURE

Coreference among mentions is captured by assigning each mention an ID that uniquely identifies the character referred to within the respective chapter.

² Eisenberg himself notes that there is no consensus on the definition of apposition. Following him, we understand an apposition as ‘an addition to a nominal noun that does not alter the scope of that noun’ (cf. Eisenberg 2020, p. 279). Analogous to copular constructions, the appositive is also considered coreferent even if the relationship is in some way non-factual.

This ID must be consistent and unique within a chapter. That is, all mentions of a given character within a chapter receive the same ID, and no other character may be assigned that ID. The ID should be a short, descriptive label for the character, such as the (first) name or another common short form by which the character is usually addressed. If multiple characters share the same label, they are numbered. The ID is entered in the *ID* field in INCEpTION.

Annotating coreference in the example above would look as follows:

EXAMPLE: “[*I*]^[ID: Elsbeth] don’t know where [*Peter*]^[ID: Peter] is,” replied [*Elsbeth*]^[ID: Elsbeth]. “[*He*]^[ID: Peter] just wanted to visit [*Master Cooper Lutz Hebenstreit*]^[ID: Lutz] one more time.” (Wolff, *Wildfangrecht*)

Mentions within **copulae** are also considered coreferent. By copulae, we mean sentences or sentence fragments in which a mention is linked to an attribute via a copular verb (such as *to be*, *to seem*, etc.; cf. Bamman et al. 2020, p. 46).

EXAMPLE: [*Kaspar*]^[ID: Kaspar] was an orphaned [*waif*]^[ID: Kaspar] [...]. (Wolff, *Wildfangrecht*)

This applies even if the relationship is in some way limited, negated, or otherwise non-factual.

EXAMPLE: As the dance was already well underway, [*Junker Ulrich von Remchingen*]^[ID: Ulrich], the [*son*]^[ID: Ulrich] of the [*Imperial Baron*]^[ID: Dietrich], appeared. A young [*cavalier*]^[ID: Ulrich] with pleasing features and dark, fiery eyes, he moved freely among the guests. He was no [*spoilsport*]^[ID: Ulrich], but a skillful [*conversationalist*]^[ID: Ulrich] and an excellent [*dancer*]^[ID: Ulrich]. (Wolff, *Wildfangrecht*)

3.3 Full name

For each character in the novel, we record a name or designation based on the information provided in the text. It appears in the overall character index in the column labeled ‘*fullname*’ at the character’s entry. It can be recorded either at the first mention of the character in INCEpTION in the *fullname* field, or later entered directly into the character index.

If the character is given a name in the text, this name is recorded in as complete a form as possible. Titles, nobiliary designations, and similar elements are considered part of the name.

If the character’s name changes over the course of the text (e.g., due to marriage), this change is also reflected in the *fullname* field.

If the character is not given a name in the text, we assign a descriptive label based on the text that is as informative as possible. In doing so, we follow the guidelines of Kröncke et al.:

“Where possible, [...] a semantically meaningful and understandable quote from the text is provided. [...] If no semantically meaningful quote is available, or if the potential quote is not self-explanatory—for example, due to metaphorical language—a self-formulated referent

designation is provided, which characterizes the referent content-wise.” (Kröncke et al. 2022, p. 26)

3.4 Gender

EXPLIKATION

By a character’s *gender*, we understand the social gender ascribed to them by the text. Since the texts being annotated are from the 19th century, it is generally assumed that gender relations are understood in a binary way.

PROCEDURE

Gender is recorded in the character’s entry in the character index using an abbreviation, with the following options:

- **f** (female)
- **m** (male)
- **u** (unknown or unspecified)
- **nb** (non-binary)
- **o** (other)
- **[free field]**

The free field can be used to enter a custom annotation if none of the predefined options is adequate.

For groups, multiple values can be assigned if appropriate. These do not need to be separated by commas but can simply be concatenated. For example, in the group entity “Eduard’s parents” in *Elective Affinities*, the values *m* and *f* can be assigned for gender, since it is clear that the members of the group have precisely these genders.

We assume that texts may use masculine forms even when characters of another gender are meant. The decisive factor is always knowledge of the historical context. If a role or designation is historically associated with a specific gender (e.g., generals), this is annotated accordingly. If no such association exists (e.g., peasants), we annotate as *u* (unknown/unspecified).

3.5 Commentary

In individual cases, decisions in any category can be commented on if necessary. Comments that pertain to the level of the mention should be entered in INCEpTION in the *comment_mention* field. Comments that pertain to the entity should be entered in the *comment_entity* field.

4) Special and Borderline Cases

4.1 Overview and General Procedure for Deviations

4.1.1 General Procedure for Deviations

Our starting point for annotation is always the *prototypical case* described above. Individual deviations should primarily be considered in relation to the rules for the *prototypical case*, rather than in relation to the rules for deviations. The guiding question is therefore: Does this case deviate from the *prototypical case* so much that it can no longer be classified there?

We distinguish between *special cases* and *borderline cases*.

By *special cases*, we mean a set of recurring cases that each deviate from the prototypical case in a specific way.

By *borderline cases*, we mean cases for which there are categories in the guidelines that could apply, but where the annotator is unsure for some reason whether the case truly belongs to that category.

As mentioned in the introduction, the terms *special case* and *borderline case* are not intended to imply that these occurrences are rare. On the contrary, certain special cases (e.g., groups, generic mentions) are expected to occur very frequently.

We first provide an overview of the special and borderline cases. Chapters 4.2 and 4.3 then describe the individual special cases in more detail. Here, we distinguish between *included* and *excluded* special cases: included special cases are generally still considered mentions or entities, while excluded special cases are not.

4.1.2 Overview Special Cases

Special cases can pertain either to the **mention level** or to the **entity level**.

Special cases affecting **mentions** are marked in INCEpTION in the *specialcase_mention* field.

Special cases affecting **entities** are marked at the first mention of the character in INCEpTION in the *specialcase_entity* field and later in the overall character index in the *specialcase* **column**. The

decision can additionally be commented on in the corresponding free comment field (*comment_mention* or *comment_entity*).

The following table provides an overview of the **included** special cases. These are the special cases that are generally still annotated as mentions or entities.

Name	Concerns	Field/Column	Short Description
group	Entity	specialcase_entity / specialcase	A group of at least two characters that is addressed together in a single mention appears as a unit and/or is difficult to resolve.
nonfact	Entity	specialcase_entity / specialcase	An entity holds a status of being <i>non-factual</i> in some way, for example, negated, hypothetical, or possible.
possible_id entity	Entity	specialcase_entity / specialcase	An entity may be identical to another entity, whereby this identity is understood as 'intended'.
[open]	Entity	specialcase_entity / specialcase	[Free field for special cases relating to the entity that are not yet included in the list]
generic	Mention	specialcase_mention	A mention does not refer to an individual or group of individuals located in a specific place and time, but rather to a timeless and abstract entity. It can be meaningfully accompanied with the phrase "in general."
figurative	Mention	specialcase_mention	A mention occurs in any form of figurative speech, e.g., as a metaphor, metonymy, or comparison.
part	Mention	specialcase_mention	A mention does not refer to the character as a whole (e.g., by name, personal pronoun, or appellative that refers to the character as a whole), but only mentions a part, often a body part, of the character. (Only recorded if there is no other mention in the same immediate context.)
[open]	Mention	specialcase_mention	[Freifeld für die Mention betreffende Sonderfälle, die bislang nicht in der Liste berücksichtigt sind]

The following table provides an overview of the **excluded** special cases, i.e., the special cases that we do not generally evaluate as mentions/entities.

Name	Concerns	Short Description
phraseologism	Mention / Entity	A human or human-like entity is mentioned in a phraseologism or other fixed expression (e.g., Oh my God!).
unspecific pronoun	Mention / Entity	The reference is entirely unspecific. Typically used with indefinite pronouns such as nobody.

4.1.3 Overview Borderline Cases

In all cases where assigning a category is difficult because the case plausibly fits multiple categories, a decision is still made, but it is additionally recorded that the case is a *borderline case*.

Borderline cases, like special cases, can pertain either to the **mention** level or the **entity** level.

Borderline cases affecting **mentions** are marked in INCEpTION in the *borderline_mention* field.

Borderline cases affecting **entities** are marked at the first mention of the character in INCEpTION in the *borderline_entity* field and later in the overall character index in the *borderline* column.

The decision can additionally be commented on in the corresponding free comment field (*comment_mention* or *comment_entity*, see Section 3.5).

The following table provides an overview of the borderline cases.

Name	Concerns	Field/Column	Short Description
nonfact	Entity	<i>borderline_entity</i>	1) It is not entirely clear whether it is really a non-factual entity (if tagged as non-factual). 2) It is not entirely clear whether it might be a non-factual entity after all (if not tagged as non-factual).
group	Entity	<i>borderline_entity</i>	1) It is not entirely clear whether it really is a group (if tagged as a group). 2) It is not entirely clear whether this might be a group

			after all (if not tagged as a group).
members	Entity	borderline_entity	1) It is not entirely clear whether the specified members actually belong to the group. 2) It is not entirely clear whether figures that have not been annotated as members might actually belong to the group.
possible_identity	Entity	borderline_entity	1) It is not entirely clear whether the entity is indeed identical to another character. 2) It is not entirely clear whether the character is, in fact, identical to another entity (if not tagged as possible_identity).
[open]	Entity	borderline_entity	Wenn es bei einer in dieser Liste nicht berücksichtigten Kategorie einen Grenzfall gibt, kann dieser frei im entsprechenden Feld eingetragen werden.
generic	Mention	borderline_mention	1) It is not entirely clear whether it is really a generic mention (if tagged as generic). 2) It is not entirely clear whether it might be a generic mention after all (if not tagged as generic).
ID	Mention	borderline_mention	It is not entirely clear whether the registered ID is correct, for example because it is not entirely clear whether it is actually this character.
mention	Mention	borderline_mention	It is not entirely clear whether the span tagged as a mention is actually a mention.

figurative	Mention	borderline_mention	1) It is not entirely clear whether this is really a mention in the form of figurative speech (if tagged as figurative). 2) It is not entirely clear whether this might be a mention in the form of figurative speech after all (if not tagged as figurative).
part	Mention	borderline_mention	1) It is not entirely clear whether it is really a mention in the form of a (body) part (if tagged as part). 2) It is not entirely clear whether it might be a mention in the form of a (body) part (if not tagged as part).
nonspecific	Mention	borderline_mention	It is not entirely clear whether this is perhaps an nonspecific mention (see indefinite pronouns) and whether the mention should therefore not have been tagged.
phraseologism	Mention	borderline_mention	It is not entirely clear whether this is perhaps a phraseologism after all and the mention should not have been tagged.
[open]	Mention	borderline_mention	Wenn es bei einer in dieser Liste nicht berücksichtigten Kategorie einen Grenzfall gibt, kann dieser frei im entsprechenden Feld eingetragen werden.

4.2 Included Special Cases

4.2.1 Groups

EXPLIKATION

A mention of a character group occurs when an expression simultaneously refers to more than one character.

Any of the forms mentioned above—pronouns, proper names, or appellatives—can be used in such cases.

Here, we deal with *non-generic* character groups, that is, groups whose members are spatially and temporally situated and specific, even if we do not know them precisely or by name. Generic groups are treated together with generic entities in Section 4.2.2.

For group mentions, we distinguish two cases, which are annotated differently.

Case 1: Group not as a unit and/or dissolvable

EXPLIKATION

The group of characters can be easily and clearly broken down into individual characters and/or does not appear as a unit.

PROCEDURE

The group does not get assigned an ID of its own; instead, the respective mention span directly gets assigned the IDs of the characters belonging to the group. A separate mention is assigned for each entity. In the following example, the spans *Mädchen* and *Ehrgeizigen* are each tagged with two characters, and the ID of the corresponding character is recorded for each mention:

EXAMPLE: *A noble competition developed between the [girls][ID: Ammerie][ID: Trudi], which the mayor could only resolve through a decisive word of authority or by bringing it to a mutually satisfying compromise, in that she agreed to forgo some of her own domestic rights and distribute them among the young ambitious [ones][ID: Ammerie][ID: Trudi].*

NOTE: The group is small (two characters) and can be clearly identified.

It can also occur that a span refers simultaneously to a Case-2 character group and to a single character.

Case 2: Group as a unit and/or not (or difficult to) dissolve

EXPLIKATION

The group of characters appears as a unit and is addressed as such (e.g., as a family) and/or cannot be easily and/or clearly broken down into individual characters, for example because it is large and/or it is not entirely clear which characters belong to it.

PROCEDURE

Such groups are treated as a single entity, just like individual characters. A group of this type is therefore assigned an ID, and later receives its own row in the character index. Additionally, in INCEpTION, the *specialcase_entity* field is set to *group* at the first mention. In the character index, the *specialcase* column for this entity should also later contain the value *group*.

EXAMPLE: The *[Armbrusters]*^[ID: Familie Armbruster, specialcase_entity: group] were already dressed in festive attire, and when the bell of the church dedicated to Saint George rang later, the mayor put on his wide-brimmed tricorne, and *[they]*^[ID: Familie Armbruster] went with Trudi to the service.

NOTE: The family addressed here is relatively large and frequently appears as a unit in the novel; therefore, the entire group is assigned a single ID.

Members of Case-2-Groups

Often, members can still be assigned to Case-2 groups. These members are recorded as completely as possible by entering their IDs at the first mention in the *members* field and later in the character index in the *members* column. The IDs of the members are separated by commas within the *members* field.

For groups that fall under Case 2 because they appear as a unit, it may also be possible to record all members. This is the case, for example, when we know the IDs of all members of the large Armbruster family and can record them accordingly. If some members can be identified but others cannot, this is indicated with an additional “x,” also separated by commas. If no members can be identified, this is indicated with a single “x.”

Case-2 groups can themselves also be members of other groups. Since we treat them as one entity, all properties of an entity potentially apply to them.

Unclear Overlap

In some cases, it is not entirely clear whether and to what extent two Case-2 groups overlap.

EXAMPLE: In Chapter 15 of Kürnberger’s *Der Amerika-Müde*, the protagonist attends a Methodist “camp meeting” in the forest. Hundreds of people gather there and spend several days, with the main focus on the conduct of worship services. When referring to all the people at the camp meeting, the text usually uses the term *Versammlung* (assembly), whereas when referring to those attending the service, it uses *Gemeinde* (congregation).

PROCEDURE

If it is unclear whether two groups are identical and the text refers to them using different terms, we treat them as two separate entities, even if a significant overlap is likely.

Spans with Simultaneous Individual and Group Reference

It is not uncommon for mentions to refer simultaneously to a Case-2 group and to an individual. The following example, the beginning of a letter from the headmistress in *Die Wahlverwandtschaften*, illustrates this case:

EXAMPLE: *“Your Graces will forgive me if I keep this brief today; for after completing the public review of what [we] accomplished last year with our pupils, I must report the results to all parents and supervisors; I may also be brief because I can say much with few words.”*

PROCEDURE

With the pronoun we, the headmistress constructs a group to which she counts herself. As is typically the case with such mentions, there are two possible ways to annotate this:

1. Treat the addressed group as a single unit (all instructors of the boarding school) and record the headmistress as a member (members) of this group. In this case, only one mention is annotated.
2. Annotate two mentions: one referring to the headmistress herself, and one referring to the group “all instructors of the boarding school except the headmistress.” The headmistress is then not a member of this group.

Which approach to choose is not predetermined, but should be decided on a case-by-case basis. A factor to consider is how the group is constituted outside of this specific mention.

Handling Multiple Partitioning

As noted above, groups can themselves be members of other groups. It can also occur that groups are “partitioned” differently at various points in the text, that is, divided into different sets of subgroups.

This can become very complex very quickly. During annotation, excessive effort should not be spent on finely resolving group members. The goal is to capture the members in a coarse-grained manner, using the current context as the starting point.

4.2.2 Generic Entities

PROCEDURE

Generic mentions are annotated as mentions but are marked as generic. To do this, the value *generic* is assigned in the *specialcase_mention* field. Coreference is not resolved for generic mentions (in contrast to version 4.0 of the guidelines), meaning they do not receive an ID.

EXPLIKATION

A *generic mention* or a mention of a *generic entity* is a mention that refers to human or human-like beings but not to an individual or a group of individuals.

We use the term *individual* in a deliberately information-poor sense.³ Prototypically, an individual is a single being in the narrated world that can be situated in space and time. Such beings often have a proper name (even if it is not explicitly mentioned in the text) and cannot meaningfully be referred to with the qualifier “in general.” As readers, we would intuitively consider such entities to be *characters*.

Generic mentions, by contrast, refer to beings that are not clearly situated in space or time. They typically do not refer to single individuals or specific groups of individuals, but to large and/or numerically indeterminate groups. These mentions usually appear in general or typical statements about such a group. Such statements are generally not tied to a specific temporal or spatial context. Readers would intuitively not consider the entities denoted by generic mentions to be *characters*.

EXAMPLE *Therefore, it is the excellent duty of a wise and faithful [vizier] to warn [his] lord daily against these most dangerous demons [...].*
(Klinger, *Faust*)

NOTE: The passage does not refer to a specific, named being at a particular place and time. Rather, it refers to a wise and faithful vizier *in general*. It is unclear how many individuals the label applies to; instead, general properties of such a type of figure are described.

An important point for decision-making: the decision is primarily made *ex negativo*. The central question is: Does the mention refer to a specific individual or a defined group of individuals and thus fall under the prototypical concept of a character? If the answer is “no,” the mention should be annotated as generic.

Mentions with Simultaneous Generic and Specific Reference

In some cases, a generic mention implicitly also refers to a specific individual. That is, it contains both generic and specific meaning components.

EXAMPLE: *It was to [him]_[ID: Franz] upon receiving the news as if a golden rain fell into [his]_[ID: Franz] lap. Life is hard in a metropolis with the income of an [assessor]_{[ID: Franz][generic mention]}.*

³ We do not want to use the term to refer to the classification in character theory into “individuals” and “types.” In other words, we do not want to distinguish between individuals and types within characters, but rather consider all prototypical characters as individuals.

(Heimburg, *Trudchen*)

The mention *assessor* initially appears generic: in general, the text says, life is difficult for assessors in a city such as Frankfurt. However, from the immediate context it is clear that *assessor* simultaneously refers to the protagonist Franz Linden. Franz was himself an assessor but has now acquired a new life situation through an inheritance. The generic statement about the life of assessors thus receives a specific interpretation relating to Franz.

PROCEDURE

If a span simultaneously refers to a generic entity and a specific individual, we assign two mention annotations:

1. One referring to the specific character, with the corresponding ID.
2. One generic mention, which does not receive an ID and has the value *generic* in the *specialcase_mention* field.

This approach preserves the dual function of the span in the text—both generic and specific.

Immediate context means that the potentially generic and specific mentions occur very close to each other. *Clear* means that it is evident, without interpretive effort, that the generic mention refers to the character.

4.2.3 Non-factual entities

PROCEDURE

Mentions of non-factual entities are annotated as mentions and marked as non-factual. For this purpose, the value *nonfact* is assigned in the *specialcase_entity* field at the first mention of the entity. The mention receives a regular mention ID (see Section 3.2).

EXPLIKATION

A mention of a non-factual entity is a mention that refers to a concrete human or human-like individual. However, this being is non-factual in some way within the narrated world, for example, nonexistent, hypothetical, possible, or only perhaps existing. As readers, we would often not intuitively consider such entities to be *characters*.

LINGUISTIC INDICATORS of non-factual characters can include, among others:

- Interrogative sentences, imperative sentences, and other non-declarative sentence types
- Conditional and subjunctive mood
- Negation
- References to the future
- Use of modal verbs (e.g., *shall*, *want to*)
- Subjunctive forms

4.2.4 Possible and Implicit Identity of Entities

EXPLIKATION

In literary texts, it can sometimes be unclear whether certain things are the case within the fictional world. This also applies to the identity of characters. A *possible/implicit identity* refers to a case in which two entities may, but are not certainly, identical, with this uncertainty being conceived as intentional.

EXAMPLE: In a sort of hymn at the beginning of Kürnberger's *Der Amerika-Müde*, the speaker in the hymn reflects on the relationship between Europe and America. It might seem natural to associate this person with the protagonist of the novel, Dr. Moorfeld. However, equating the two would contradict the intuition that a hymn represents a fictional textual form in which author and speaker are not necessarily the same.

PROCEDURE: We annotate the speaking instance and Dr. Moorfeld as separate entities, but link them via *possible_identity_with*.

PROCEDURE

Entities that are implicitly or possibly identical are marked accordingly. At the first mention of the character, the value *possible_identity* is entered in the *specialcase_entity* field, and the ID of the character with which the mentioned entity may be identical is entered in the *possible_identity_with* field.

4.2.5 Figurative Speech

PROCEDURE

Mentions in the form of *figurative speech*, for example in metaphors, similes, and metonymies, are annotated as such when it is clear and unambiguous that they constitute a mention. The value *figurative* is entered in the *specialcase_mention* field.

EXAMPLE METAPHOR: "Now explain to me, please," the friend shouted at him, "how do you come to this [man]—what shall I say—this [rat] that intrudes so unsolicitedly into your affairs?"

(Heimburg, *Trudchen*)

EXAMPLE METONYMY: How terribly my good, weak aunt was startled when she saw me, pale and disfigured, entering her room. The entire [house] was set in motion.

(Fischer, *Gustav*)

A mention is *not* considered figurative when meanings of originally figurative expressions have become lexicalized and conventionalized.

4.2.6 Parts of Characters as Mentions

PROCEDURE

When only *parts* of a character—such as body parts or other components belonging to the character—are mentioned, but not the character as a whole, we treat this as a mention only if the character is not mentioned elsewhere in the same context (sentence or immediate surrounding context) by other linguistic means. The value *part* is entered in the *specialcase_mention* field.

In the following example, *voice* is treated as a mention:

EXAMPLE: *“Where are you, Marie?” — called a [voice] from behind the arbor — “Marie!” — I repeated — and stretched my arms longingly toward the arbor.*
(Fischer, *Gustav*)

4.3 Excluded Special Cases

4.3.1 Nonspecific Pronouns

PROCEDURE

If a reference is made to an entity but it remains completely indefinite, we do **not** annotate it as a mention. The prototypical cases are certain pronoun groups:

- Indefinite pronouns (e.g., *everyone*, *no one*, *someone*)
- Interrogative pronouns (e.g., *who*, *which*)
- Pronouns used generically (e.g., generic *you*, generic *one*)

Only if the context clearly indicates that such a pronoun refers to a specific or generic entity do we annotate it as a mention.

The same applies to expressions equivalent in meaning to such pronouns, which could in principle be replaced by them.

4.3.2 Phraseologisms

PROCEDURE

If a human or human-like being is mentioned within a phraseologism or other fixed expression, we do **not** annotate it as a mention.

Typical cases include expressions such as “God,” or “Jesus Christ”.

EXAMPLE: *“No, by God!” I exclaimed, with a bitter smile — [...]*

(Fischer, *Gustav*)

5) Knowledge Base for Annotation

In principle, the knowledge on which the annotation is based corresponds to the full knowledge of the entire text. The annotation reflects this “static” knowledge rather than the dynamically changing knowledge of a first reading of the text.

EXAMPLE: In Wilhelmine Heimbürg’s novel *Trudchens Heirat*, the protagonist Trudchen Baumhagen meets her future husband Franz Linden for the first time in a church. In the corresponding scene, however, Franz is focalized, and since he does not know Trudchen and they do not introduce themselves, Trudchen is consistently referred to as *the girl* or similar:

After the ceremony, the [girl]^[ID: Trudchen] carried the child to her weeping mother and pressed a kiss on the little red face; then [she]^[ID: Trudchen] came over to Linden, and her eyes looked at him with a mixture of wonder and gratitude.

(Heimbürg, *Trudchen*)

NOTE: For annotation, we assume the knowledge of the full text. Since we know that this is Trudchen Baumhagen, we identify her as such.

The assumed contextual knowledge is that of a contemporary *historical ideal reader* of the text, not the annotator. For example, if a word currently in use appears whose reference to a human entity is unclear, it should be looked up and treated according to its contemporary meaning.

Major Changes in a Character

It can occur that a character undergoes significant changes over the course of the narrative. Roesiger et al. raise the question of whether a character experiencing very drastic changes should still be considered the same character.

EXAMPLE: The transformation of Saul into Paul in the New Testament.

According to our static approach, we consider a character to remain the same even in the face of significant changes, and we treat their mentions as coreferent accordingly.

Revealed Identity

In some novels, it only becomes apparent after some time that one character is actually identical with another. This implies that there is a period during which it is not clear that the two entities are the same.

EXAMPLE: In Klinger's *Der Faust der Morgenländer*, a narrator named Ben Hafi tells a story to a caliph every evening. Toward the end of the novel, it is revealed that Ben Hafi is the caliph's long-lost brother Abdallah.

PROCEDURE: Mentions referring to the caliph's brother are resolved in the same way as mentions referring to Ben Hafi, such that they all refer to the same entity: Brother Abdallah/Ben Hafi.

PROCEDURE

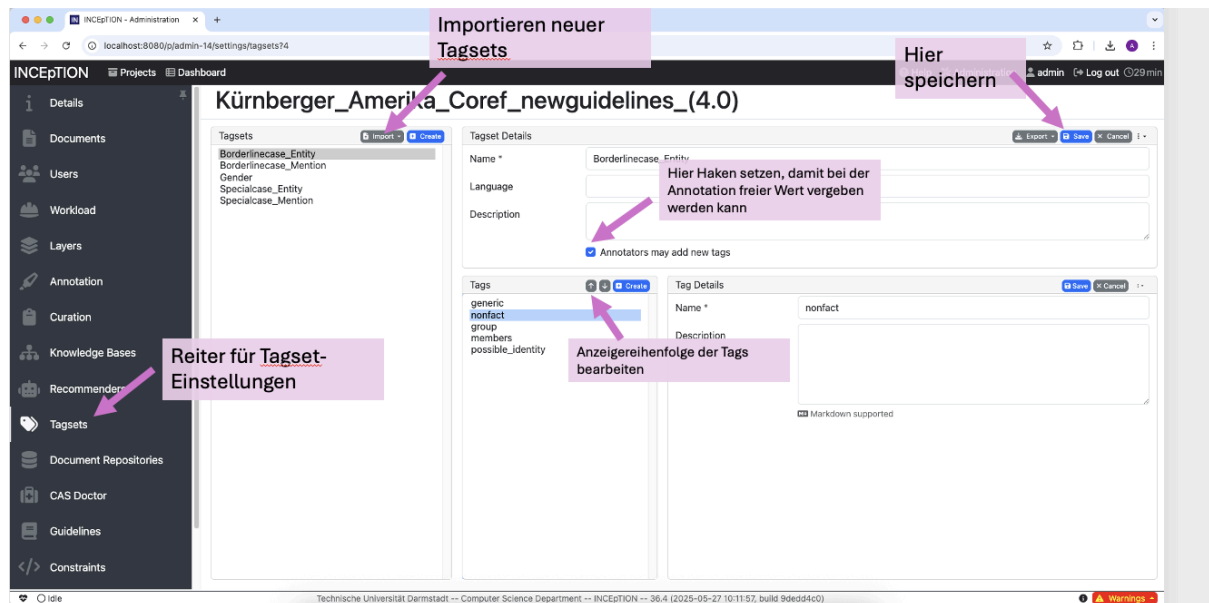
For annotation, we assume knowledge of the entire text. Mentions are annotated as referring to the same entity based on this full-text knowledge, even if this information only becomes accessible later in the novel.

6) Setting Up INCEpTION

At the beginning of the annotation process, an empty Inception project is created (*Blank project (no layers)*). The current type system and tag sets are then imported. **These are stored on Google Drive (or later on GitHub).**

Importing and Configuring the Tag Sets: Within the INCEpTION project, select **Settings** and then **Tagsets** in the left-hand menu. Use **Import** to import the five tag sets.

Once the tag sets have been imported, check the box **Annotators may add new tags** for all tag sets and click **Save**. (This setting allows us to enter custom values later.) The tag sets define the possible tags that can be assigned within a category. These possible tags are displayed in the **Tags** field for each tag set. By default, the tags are listed in alphabetical order. This order can be adjusted if necessary using the small arrow icons.



Importing and Configuring the Layers

Within the INCEpTION project, select **Settings** and then **Layers** in the left-hand menu. Use **Import** to import the file *TypeSystem.xml*.

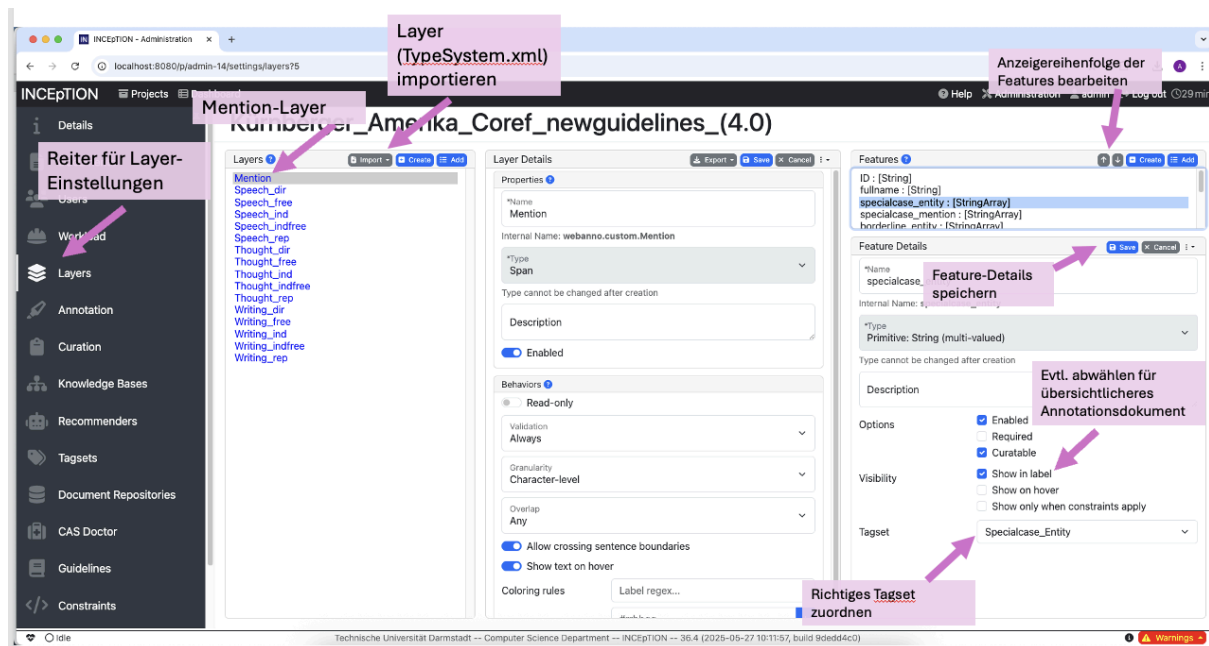
Next, select the layer **Mention**.

A few adjustments need to be made to the **Features** of the **Mention** layer, which are displayed in the rightmost column. For each of the five features for which we previously imported tag sets (*group*, *specialcase_entity*, *specialcase_mention*, *borderline_entity*, *borderline_mention*), assign the corresponding tag set.

To do this, click on the feature. A **Feature Details** field will appear at the bottom. At the very bottom of this field, select and assign the appropriate tag set under **Tagsets**, then click **Save**.

The display order of the features can also be adjusted using the small gray arrows if needed.

Additionally, in the **Feature Details** field, you can uncheck the box next to **Show in Label** if you do not want a particular feature to appear in the label displayed during annotation in the running text. This is useful to avoid cluttering the annotation document, especially for features such as *comment_mention* and *comment_entity*.

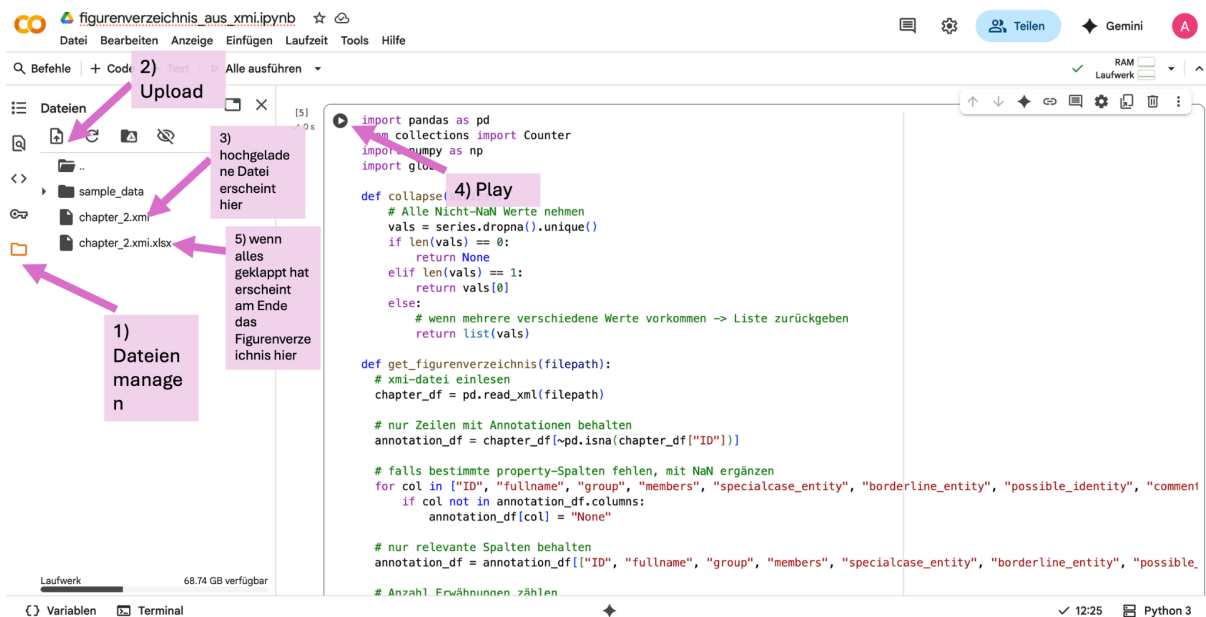


7) Generating the Character Index

To generate the chapter-level character index, the Python script provided in the Google Colab notebook *figurenverzeichnis_aus_xmi.ipynb* is used.

First, under **Files** and then **Upload**, upload the corresponding XMI file.

Once the file has been uploaded, it will appear in the file manager. Then, click the **Play** button to execute the Python script. Once the script has successfully run, the Excel file containing the character index will appear in the file list and can be downloaded.



The script can also be executed for multiple files; instead of one, any number of xmi files can be uploaded.

8) Change Log

Compared to Version 4.0

- For generic mentions, coreference is no longer resolved. That is, a generic mention no longer receives an ID, but only the attribute *generic*. This reduces the cognitive effort during annotation, as in practice it often proves difficult to decide when two generic mentions are coreferent.
- Rules for group annotation are described in more detail (members, unclear overlap, simultaneous individual and group reference).
- More precise rules for *nonfact* have been added.
- More precise rules for *gender* have been added.
- More precise rules regarding the knowledge state have been added, with changes in characters and revealed identity now treated as separate subsections.
- Examples have been updated

Compared to Version 3.0

- Introduction of the class *borderline* for borderline cases.
- Conceptual distinction between special cases and borderline cases.
- Introduction of free-text fields for special and borderline cases.

- Appositions are no longer treated as a separate special case but subsumed under the prototypical case.
- Parts of characters are counted as mentions only if the character is addressed solely through them.
- Introduction of the field *commentary*.
- Increased precision and slightly modified procedure for groups.
- Removal of the chapter with the extended example (it was too detailed).

Compared to Version 2.0

- Instead of manually editing the Excel table alongside the annotation, it is now generated automatically after annotating a chapter, producing both a chapter-level character list and a global character list.
- The attributes *generic*, *nonfact*, and *group* are recorded directly in Inception.
- A set of rules for special cases has been established.

9) Bibliography

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